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On the Task and Procedure of the Philosophy of Religion.

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I.

By philosophy of religion one may understand two different endeavours. One may [411] mean a philosophizing, a thinking, which springs from the religious consciousness as an attempt to gain clarity about itself, about the direction and the object of its innermost need, and about the manner in which that need is satisfied. Such reflection arises when religion no longer has the character of immediate feeling or instinct, or of secure repose in tradition; but it still moves within religion's own presuppositions. Religion is ground and point of departure, not properly object. I should rather call such an endeavour religious thinking than philosophy of religion. Some of the greatest minds who have lived have contributed to this kind of thinking: Augustine, the mystics of the Middle Ages, Pascal, Jacobi, Kierkegaard. — By philosophy of religion one may also understand, and I here understand, a philosophizing, a thinking about religion as a given psychological and historical phenomenon. Here religion is object, not subject. That religious thinking itself falls under what is here the object, since in many ways it sets religion in a clearer light, draws consequences and opens insights which the unreflective religious consciousness [412] does not afford.

A philosophy of religion in the sense in which I take the word presupposes that a religious problem exists. And this presupposes in turn that religion is not the only form of spiritual culture, and further, that several different religious standpoints assert themselves in greater or lesser opposition to one another. The philosophy of religion is comparative: by comparing religion with other spiritual endeavours, and by comparing different religious tendencies with one another, it seeks to find religion's proper essence and principle — if possible, to formulate this in a single proposition which the various religions and religious standpoints seek to maintain, in more or less consistent and pronounced form and in different garbs. Such a proposition must of course have a certain abstract form, and in this form it exists only in the philosophy of religion, just

as, for example, the laws of the association of ideas exist only in psychology, while it is nevertheless in accordance with them that the ideas of practical consciousness combine.

A religious problem cannot arise at any and every time. It presupposes a differentiation, or a division of labour, in the spiritual domain. It does not exist in religion's classical ages — neither in the great ages of beginning, where religious interest immediately and completely lays claim to all energy, nor in the great ages of organization, where other spiritual endeavours do indeed assert themselves, but where they all subordinate themselves to religion and derive from it their ultimate criteria and regulative principles. In religion's classical ages there may be religious thinking, but no philosophy of religion proper. The religious problem presupposes that the unity and the harmony of the spiritual domain has been broken, or at any rate challenged. Science and art, morality and social life develop and organize themselves according to their own laws, on their own independent foundations, and stand as independent spiritual powers over against religion. And within religion different tendencies likewise assert themselves; indeed [413] the differences may even concern what is held, from the one side or the other, to be the essential thing in religion.

The question then becomes what significance religion can have under these conditions. If it is religion's essence to be the only form of spiritual culture, and if it lies in religion's essence to appear under one single determinate form, then it is clear that its time is past once spiritual division of labour and differentiation have appeared. And in fact such an assertion is often heard — while on the other side it is maintained that the whole intellectual, aesthetic, moral and social development that has taken place has not altered religion's position within the life of the spirit in the least. That such opposed assertions can be advanced shows that there really is a problem here.

It is not likely that this problem will admit of solution. In the spiritual domain we are far less able than in the physical to distinguish the individual elements and forces clearly and to find the laws of their interaction, so as to be able to decide plainly whether the conditions of life for the continued persistence of a spiritual tendency will remain present or not.

For the investigation of this question it will be of no use to set philosophy, as a finished system, over against religion. It is philosophy as organ, as many-sided discussion of the life of the spirit and its conditions, that is needed here. It may of course have its interest to investigate how a fully developed philosophical world-view stands to religion. But in the first place such a system has more the character of art than of science; it stands to investigative philosophy as the writing of history stands to historical criticism. And in the second place a philosophical system will have value only if, already in its coming-to-be and its preparation, it has taken due account of such a spiritual fact as religion is. It will then be natural, in discussing the religious problem, to employ philosophy in its [414] investigative and preparatory shape. Philosophy in this sense is a critical and comparative discipline, which seeks out the fundamental forms and fundamental presuppositions

of the life of consciousness, and the conditions of their persistence and their validity. Its method is essentially analytic-genetic, in that from the finished works and forms it goes back to the forces and elements out of which they have arisen. An investigation of religion of this kind may suitably be laid out so as to consist of an epistemological, a psychological and an ethical part. — I shall attempt to give a condensed survey of such an investigation.

II.

In religion's classical ages, in which it was all in all, religious ideas furnished a satisfying explanation and understanding of existence. There has now developed a need for understanding which is not met by these ideas. The individual phenomenon, the individual event in the spiritual and in the material world, is understood (on this new conception of understanding) by being brought into the closest continuous connection with other phenomena and events, each of which can be exhibited in experience just as well as those whose explanation was asked for. It is required that the cause, no less than the effect, shall be an experience. It is now acknowledged more and more (though this has cost hard and repeated struggles) that it is not religion's business to furnish an understanding of this kind. And when the two modes of explanation collide over one and the same phenomenon, the question becomes how they are to be reconciled, and whether on the whole they can be. This much, however, seems on the whole to be generally conceded: that religious ideas do not have their significance and their value in being required to afford full satisfaction of the need for knowledge. It is then probable that religious ideas owe their origin and their persistence to sides of the life of consciousness other than the intellectual. [415]

One might suppose that it was only the individual, particular phenomena that science could explain, while the concluding questions, the ultimate riddles, had to be sought answered in religion. But if it now turns out, on closer critical investigation, that religion is as little able as science to solve the ultimate riddles, to give us really conclusive and consistent concepts, then the question of the significance of religious ideas returns with renewed force. It turns out (as it would be too lengthy to establish here in detail) that religious ideas are essentially due to analogy, without the analogies that here lie at the basis being capable of being formed and applied in so clear and thoroughgoing a manner as the analogies of which scientific thinking makes use in various domains. This is no accident; for as it stands with religious ideas, so it stands also with the thoughts by which speculative philosophy, in the various metaphysical systems, has attempted to give a conclusion to the understanding of existence. There comes a point here at which thought is relieved by poetry. Religious ideas do indeed have throughout a figurative character. They are great symbols in which spiritual states of another kind and compass than the

purely intellectual have sought and found expression. — At this point the epistemological philosophy of religion leads naturally over into the psychological.

III.

This part of the science of religion will more and more become the most important, and it is the part that has offered me the greatest interest. Here we are led away from the strife between dogmatics and criticism, back to the life of the soul in its inmost and most concentrated forms. Religion cannot be made or constructed. It grows out of life, springs [416] from man's fundamental mood in the struggle of life, from his will to hold fast to what is of highest value, which his experiences have led him to know. We do not always come to know it so well from this side with the help of the history of religion, significant as that of course otherwise is. In the history of religion one does not so easily get to see the forces of the soul in their original working. It occupies itself more with religion's works than with religion itself — more with the outward occasions and conditions than with the inner life — more with the great types, the forms common to large groups of men, than with the individual processes. The study of individual religiosity, as this can be known from the biographies, and especially the autobiographies, of religious personalities, is therefore of the greatest importance for the psychology of religion. Augustine's *Confessions*, and the autobiographies of Suso and of St. Teresa, are psychological source-documents of the first rank. There is of course, and particularly in the religious domain, a close connection between individual and society, and an investigation of the relation between individual religiosity and religious tradition is therefore one of the most important chapters in the psychology of religion. Individual religiosity belongs moreover to the history of religion as well, although that discipline has hitherto occupied itself almost exclusively with the great types and has disregarded the manifold ways in which they are shaded in single individuals. And yet it is really only through these shadings that the operative forces and elements come clearly to light.

There are two concepts which it is above all the business of the psychology of religion to determine: religious experience and religious faith.

The peculiarity of religious experience I find in this, that whereas other experiences concern either the given reality — which holds of the experiences we make through the various senses — or the value this reality has for us — which holds of the experiences due to organic vital feeling and to aesthetic, intellectual and ethical feeling — religious [417] experience, or religious feeling, concerns the relation between value and reality. It is determined by the fate of what is of value in the world of reality. — The peculiarity of religious faith I find in this, that amid the course of actual events it holds fast to the persistence of value. It is a deep trust, a continuity in the mind through all fluctuations. Its objective content is a continuity too: its fundamental assumption is — anthropomorphically expressed — a faithfulness in existence, which shows itself in the fact that the values persist, however much their particular forms may change.

The correctness of this psychological characterization may be established along several routes. In the first place, it is possible, on the basis of the marks given, to describe a direction of feeling and of will which must naturally develop under human conditions of life and in virtue of the general psychological laws. It is a psychologically possible state. In the second place, by employing this description, and calling what it describes religion, one will be able to exhibit clearly and distinctly the difference of religious feeling from, and its relation to, the other kinds of feeling with which it is akin. And in the third place, an investigation of the most important historically given types of religion shows that the marks named are the most important and the pervasive ones.

The proposition of the persistence of value may be said to be the religious axiom. It expresses a fundamental thought which the religious consciousness holds fast under the most various forms, and which, in the debate between different religious standpoints, emerges more or less distinctly as ideal and as standard. The difference between religious standpoints rests partly on the values in whose persistence one believes, partly on the clarity with which the thought of the persistence of values emerges and is held fast, partly on the different ways in which it is expressed. For the single determinate religion the essential thing is no doubt the determinate form in which it expresses the axiom. But for the comparative investigation the point is to find the typical, the theme, which [418] in the particular case may be varied in many ways.

With the help of the hypothesis thus grounded it now becomes possible to discuss the question that is the kernel of the religious problem, namely that of religion's persistence under the altered conditions which the division of labour in the spiritual domain brings with it. If the hypothesis is right, a distinction will have to be drawn between religion's form and its kernel. The forms — myths and dogmas — may change and the kernel yet persist. That is why purely intellectual criticism is in the end of such subordinate importance. Because certain religious ideas fall away, the essential motive for the formation of those ideas does not fall away. It may express itself in new effects, just as the need to find causes does not fall away because certain causal explanations have proved invalid. Religion's time would be past only if it could be proved impossible to hold fast to the assumption of the persistence of value.

The religious axiom cannot be derived from science. Scientific thinking has completed its work when it has exhibited as many relations of identity, of rationality and of causality as are possible for it at a given time. The picture of the world that thereby arises retains its validity, whatever the fate of the values in the world of reality may turn out to be. But the religious axiom, on the other hand, need not lead to conflict with the scientific picture of the world, although in fact this has often been the case. The possibility is not excluded that it might be expressed in a way that excluded such a conflict. Or the very forms and laws of the actual picture of the world might stand precisely as the ways and the means that make the persistence of value possible. It would be the ideal if the standpoint of value and the standpoint of reality could in the end coincide. From the standpoint of

critical philosophy the question cannot be held back, whether the difference we draw, and must draw, between value and reality is not merely subjective and human. This difference might well rest on the fact that both our concept of value and our concept of reality are imperfect, unconcluded and inconcludable. We can derive neither value from reality nor reality from value. Our thought is then directed to the possibility of a principle from which the persistence of value and the fixed connection of reality might spring at one and the same time. But it is a thought that cannot be carried through scientifically. [419]

There will always be matter enough for strife in the religious domain. There may be strife about which values they are in whose persistence one is to believe, and there will be strife about the right forms of the faith in the persistence of those values. But the fundamental religious point of contention will be whether the religious axiom itself can be maintained. More than a possibility of this cannot be established theoretically, if it is right that all faith is a matter of life. But life is perhaps richer and more fruitful than narrow-minded doubts and narrow-minded dogmas suppose.

IV.

The ethical philosophy of religion naturally forms the conclusion of the whole investigation. It examines two main questions, namely how far religion is the foundation of ethics, and what significance religion has — even should that not be the case — as a form of spiritual culture. Both questions may gain in clarity with the help of the hypothesis that faith in the persistence of value is the essential thing in religion.

The values in whose persistence a man believes he must first know for himself from experience. When ethical ideas appear in religious form — when, for example, the gods appear with ethical attributes — the presupposition is that these ideas or attributes have proved their value in human life itself. Only so can a man connect any meaning with them when they are used to express the divine. Historians of religion therefore lay great weight on the development of men's ethical ideas as the condition of the most important opposition within the history of religion, the opposition between nature-religion and ethical religion. Both historically and purely logically considered, the ethical has therefore priority in relation to the religious. And this emerges particularly in the fact that religious debates lead back in the end to ethical oppositions, to a difference of valuation — that is, to a difference in respect of the values in whose persistence one believes. [420]

But even if this is right, the relation between religion and ethics is not thereby exhausted. From a purely ethical standpoint it must still be asked: what value is there in believing in the persistence of value? That is the question of religion's significance as a form of spiritual culture. The treatment of this question calls for a thorough psychological and sociological investigation. Psychologically considered, such a faith

has its significance in strengthening the will and in the widening of the horizon to which it leads. Faith in the persistence of value allows us — even where we cannot follow the metamorphoses of value in detail — to view existence as a great system of potential values, which in part are to be converted through human labour into actual values. Through its inmost root the ethical consciousness here hangs together with the religious. Faith in the persistence of value acquires in ethics a significance similar to that which ideas, anticipations and hypotheses have in the theoretical domain. An anxious clinging to given experiences easily shuts one out from making new experiences. Already old Heraclitus said: If you do not hope, you will not find out that which could not be hoped for. Sociologically, religion has its great significance through its organization and through the philanthropic activity it calls forth.

A more or less sharp relation of opposition between religion and ethics arises not only when religion sets up commands or prohibitions which ethically cannot be acknowledged. The most characteristic opposition arises when faith in the persistence of value itself becomes a hindrance to the work of discovering and producing values, by laying claim [421] to energy and time that might otherwise have been used in the service of that work. If there are those whose whole energy is spent in such work, the question becomes whether it diminishes the value of their personality that they do not — at any rate not with full consciousness — believe in the persistence of value in any form whatever. This is perhaps the most decisive form in which the religious problem can present itself.

It seems, then, that the view in the philosophy of religion which has here been indicated in broad outline has not only psychological and historical grounding, but is also able to furnish important points of view for the struggle in the religious domain.